

interested in the discussion, but I was surprised to see his reactions every time someone used the term 'open source' or 'intellectual property'. Then he took the microphone and clarified certain doubts about the ambiguity of the term 'intellectual property'. He also said, "This is confusion; every time someone used that term, it meant that either the person himself is confused or is trying to confuse others." I was filled with awe at how this man could keep an ear open to what was happening around, while reading a book. Then came his speech, covering in the best possible way the definition of free software, its cause, and the issues surrounding the world of computing.

Later, when Jaijit came to speak he deliberately removed the obstacles hiding the Windows machines. RMS was obviously shocked to notice Windows running there. Jaijit tried to open an ODT file on Windows MS Word and it did not open. The message was clear—Windows can't do a lot of basic things. Jaijit explained that alone was the sole purpose of the Windows machines there. The dramatic presentation left RMS impressed.

Then we went for a meeting, which I can't write about here. But I trust the repercussions of that meeting will be soon known in India.

After finishing with their roles at the event, RMS and Dora wanted to buy some books and clothes, as Dora had not expected it to be so cold in Delhi. We first went to pick up some cookery books that RMS wanted, and then to Dilli Haat to buy some clothes. Now, while Dora was doing all the shopping RMS was either replying to e-mails on his laptop or reading his book. At one point I asked him what he found more difficult—dealing with the opposite sex or with proprietary software companies. He said, "Well, I don't deal with proprietary companies, but I do deal with women... I have no interest in dealing with any proprietary companies, but I do like hanging out with her. But yes, dealing with a woman is a bit difficult."

I recalled a discussion with one of my colleagues who once said that a country like India needed dictatorship after independence to first teach people how to be good citizens before handing them the power of democracy. I asked RMS what he thought about that. He felt that democracy was always the best option, because the one who has power may abuse it. But in a democracy you have the choice to replace the person. His reasoning was based on the question: "What is the guarantee that the dictator you bring in will do the right things only?" Then you will have no power to replace him. And things will take their own sweet time to improve.

After that we bought some more non-Coca Cola water and went for a dinner organised by Jaijit. Over dinner he told me that he also writes science fiction and booted his laptop to show me two of his science fiction stories. I was just amazed at this man. He has given us free software, he has created the GPL, and he is a sci-fiction writer as well! The stories were awesome and I became a fan immediately. Even during the dinner, which he enjoyed a

A preacher who practices

While on the move in Delhi, we were approached by some beggars with a wounded child. While Dora gave out money, RMS refused. He said that the kid may not be really wounded, and said that they just find it easier to beg. There was a minor argument between them. He was clear that if somebody was asking for money for food, he would rather go and buy the food for them. Interestingly, at Janpath, a beggar came to us with a Euro coin. RMS took the coin and started calculating how much that meant in Indian currency, and then pulled the money out and handed it to the beggars. Well, he sure is a guy who not only preaches but also practices what he preaches!



lot, he would pick up his laptop and reply to some e-mail or the other. It seemed he wasn't in a mood for (free as in...) free beer like us, and settled with some other drink. After that we returned to the guest house. He again needed the Internet connection, which wasn't available in his room and I looked for some browsing centres while they waited in the car, but everything was closed, as it was already midnight.

The next day, RMS was going to deliver a lecture at the JNU. In the morning, we first met a few government secretaries for media, IT and science. There he was convincing them about the benefits of using free software and why it mattered to governments. We came back to JNU, and then Dora needed to do some shopping so I took her to the Janpath market (near Connaught Place in central Delhi). The next day they planned to go to Agra. And I went back to my office.

RMS was to leave Delhi on Sunday, so we went out for lunch. It was nice food—though, he didn't like it spicy. I shared with him the science fiction I was writing on free software; he listened to the whole story and said it had potential, before making a lot of suggestions as well as helping me tighten the plot a bit. We then went to the airport and he left for Hyderabad.

I don't know if this was a dream or reality. I got to spend three days with the man who has changed the shape of this world and has ensured that we will never become slaves to the multinationals. He has set us free, I thought, as I bid goodbye to the free man! 

[Note: This is my interpretation/perception of RMS. If there are any minor differences in his actual idealism and my interpretation of it, the mistake would be mine.]

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A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff, and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EFYTimes.com*.